

The Missionary Behind the Legend

Patrick was a Baptist missionary sent to Ireland by the independent church in Britain to preach the gospel. In his own surviving words, the Confessio, Patrick describes salvation by grace through faith with a clarity that would be at home in any evangelical pulpit today:

> **Confessio 4**
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> *"…He poured out his Holy Spirit on us in abundance, the gift and pledge of immortality, which makes the believers and the obedient into sons of God and co-heirs of Christ who is revealed… Let every tongue confess that Jesus Christ, in whom we believe and whom we await to come back to us… is Lord and God. He is judge of the living and of the dead; he rewards every person according to their deeds."*

> **Confessio 14–15**
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> *"In the knowledge of this faith in the Trinity… it is right to make known the gift of God and his eternal consolation… I didn't deserve at all that the Lord would grant such great grace, after hardships and troubles, after captivity, and after so many years among that people."*

Patrick affirms that obedience to the gospel, and receiving the gift of eternal life and sonship as co-heirs with Christ, is by the grace of God and received by faith.

> **Confessio 3**
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> *"Hence I cannot be silent… about the great benefits and the great grace which the Lord has deigned to bestow upon me in the land of my captivity… for this we can give to God in return after having been chastened by Him, to exalt and praise His wonders."*

The New Birth: Coming to Faith

Confessio 38

“I am very much God’s debtor, who gave me such grace that many people were reborn in God through me and afterwards confirmed… for a people just coming to the faith, whom the Lord took from the utmost parts of the earth.”

Patrick saw the new birth—eternal life, regeneration—as coming by grace to those “coming to the faith.” Faith is the response to the gospel call. His isolation from the Augustine–Pelagius controversy meant he was notably silent on determinism, preaching instead a pure gospel of grace received by faith.

Confessio 12

“Before I was brought low, I was like a stone lying deep in the mud. Then he who is powerful came and in his mercy pulled me out, and lifted me up… That is why I must shout aloud in return to the Lord for such great good deeds of his… which the human mind cannot measure.”

In Confessio 12, Patrick echoes the same amazement at the grace of God that saves a wretch—the same sovereign grace that reaches every sinner who believes.

A Great Soul Winner

Confessio 33

“The Spirit was fervent within me… I pray to God to give me perseverance and to deign that I be a faithful witness to Him to the end of my life for my God.”

That same drive is what we should strive for today. Patrick was a great soul winner. We should emulate him and his passion for the gospel—not the drunken revelry and excess that Catholics have attached to his legacy. Green beer and bawdy behavior are more fitting with the pagans he preached to than with those professing Christ.

Confessio 41

“How has it lately come about in Ireland that those who never had any knowledge of God… have now been made a people of the Lord, and are called sons of God… How many have been reborn there so as to be of our kind, I do not know…”

It was this love of God and the people of Ireland that gave him innumerable souls won to the Lord. Reclaiming his legacy from Catholic hagiography reveals what he truly was: an inspiration to not faint in adversity or fall into the snares of the world.

Confessio 16

“The love of God and His fear came to me more and more, and my faith was strengthened. Faith grew, and my spirit was moved…”

Patrick’s doctrine shines clearly through his writings: eternal life is by grace alone, through faith alone, in Christ alone.

An Independent Church, Free from Rome

Stripping away the invented Catholic hagiography reveals that independent churches existed in the 4th and 5th centuries with tenuous or no ties to Rome or papal authority—and that their understanding of the gospel was the same biblical understanding held by Baptists today.

Patrick, as an evangelical figure from a non-Roman British church tradition independent of papal authority, does away with the common tropes Catholics claim always existed in the church. He relies on Scripture alone, emphasizes a believer’s response to the gospel, and avoids entirely Catholic elements such as intercession of saints, Mary, purgatory, falling from grace, priestly confession, and veneration of images—all completely absent from his writings, which are entirely gospel-focused.

His Confessio shows no appeal to Rome for legitimacy, but a strong focus on personal faith and grace. His mission stands as the first documented major independent missionary enterprise in the post-apostolic era.

The most reputable biographies confirm that Patrick was British (born approximately late 4th–early 5th century), enslaved in Ireland as a youth, escaped, then trained and ordained in Britain—likely in the church his father and grandfather served as elders—and returned as a missionary around 432 AD. A third-generation Christian, his patriarchal lineage carried a near-direct line to first-century Christianity.

He describes his authority as divinely called; he appeals to no pope or hierarchy for validation. His Confessio defends his mission against British critics who questioned his calling to the very people who had enslaved him.

Believer’s Baptism: No Infants in His Writings

Patrick does not describe or mention infant baptism (paedobaptism) at any point in his writings. The two surviving documents universally accepted as genuinely from Patrick himself—the Confessio and the Letter to the Soldiers of Coroticus (Epistola)—contain several references to baptism, but every one of them describes the baptism of converted believers: adults or those who had come to faith through hearing the gospel and confessing their faith.

Patrick emphasizes baptism in the context of missionary preaching: teaching first, then baptizing those who believe—aligning precisely with the Great Commission, which he quotes repeatedly. All water baptisms Patrick mentions are of converted believers who have responded to the gospel. No babies or infants are referenced anywhere.

The true gospel of eternal life and believer’s baptism were all he knew, and all he related to others.

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